MODULE 11 · AMBITIOUS ENTREPRENEURSHIP

Founder Health

How do you build a company without breaking yourself?

COURSE PATH



COURSE MATERIAL · SCAN NOW

All slides live on GitHub

The newest version, free, no account needed

github.com/BaNburger/
AmbitiousEntrepreneurship

1. **Open the link**
   github.com/BaNburger/AmbitiousEntrepreneurship
2. **Go to modules**
   then 11-founder-health
3. **Click the lecture PDF**
   M11_Lecture_Founder-Health.pdf, download top right

Public course repository of Ambitious Entrepreneurship. The QR code opens github.com/BaNburger/AmbitiousEntrepreneurship.

BEFORE WE START

Today is personal

Nothing you say is collected, graded or read out



Share what you choose



Sit out anything, no reason needed



Where to get help is at the end

WHERE WE ARE · THE COURSE

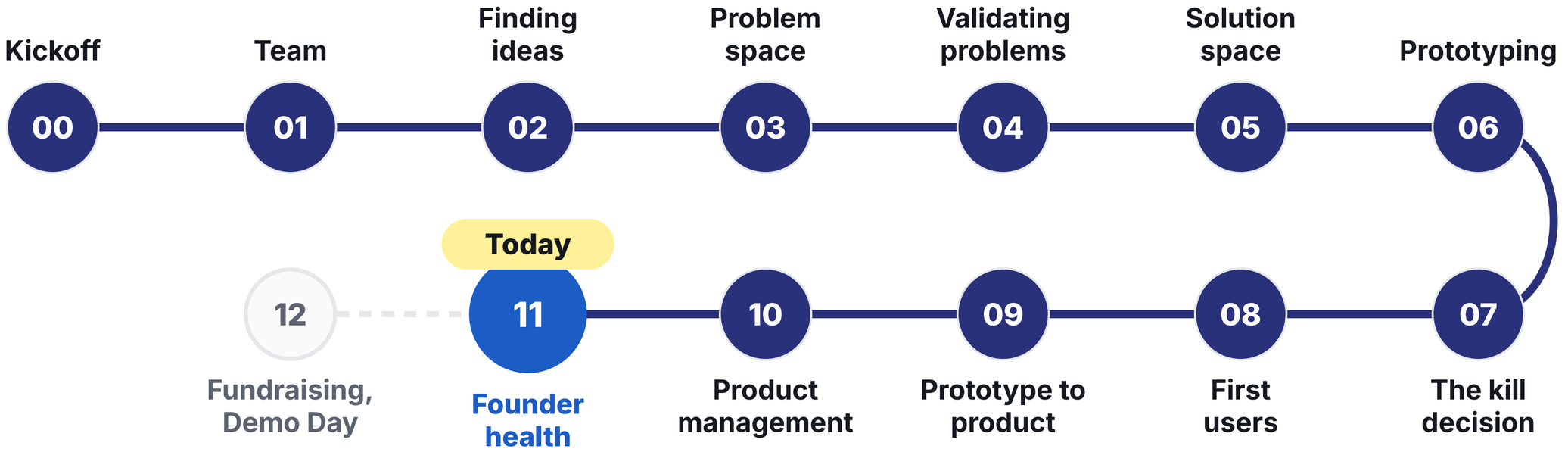
From the venture to the founders

Thirteen sessions from first idea to first revenue. What teams have by now:

Paying customers from strangers
First users (M08)

A North Star and its drivers
Product management (M10)

A team agreement, written early
Team (M01)



CHECK-IN · TABLE TALK

Which failure are you secretly proud of?

3:00

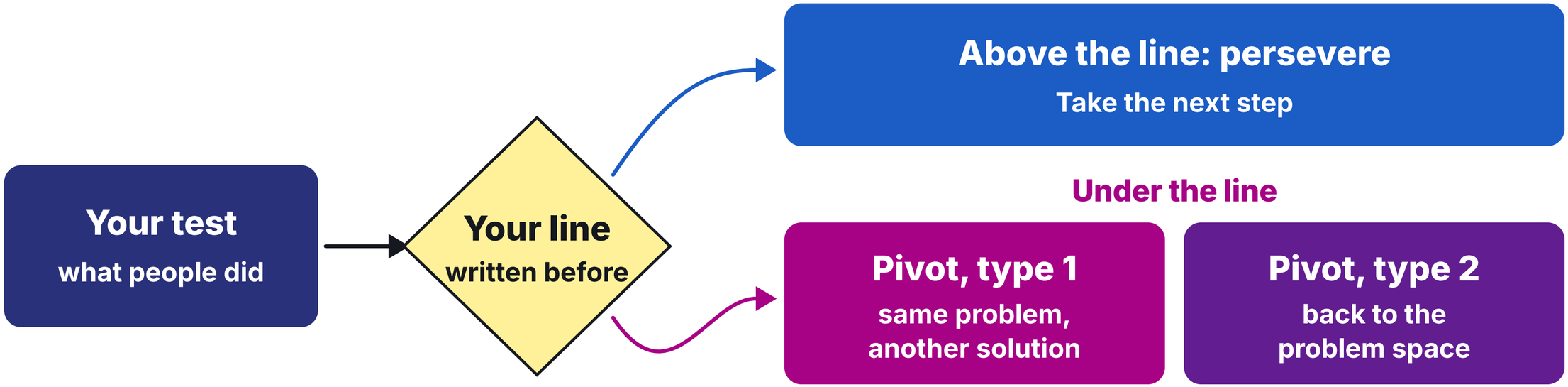


Photo: StockSnap on Pixabay.

PIVOT OR PERSEVERE

Under your line? That is a decision, not a failure

Did half your paying customers come back?



Both are progress. The only miss: no line, so no decision

FRAMEWORK Pivot or persevere after Ries, E. (2011), The Lean Startup. Pivot types as in the course Glossary.

CHAPTER 1 OF 12

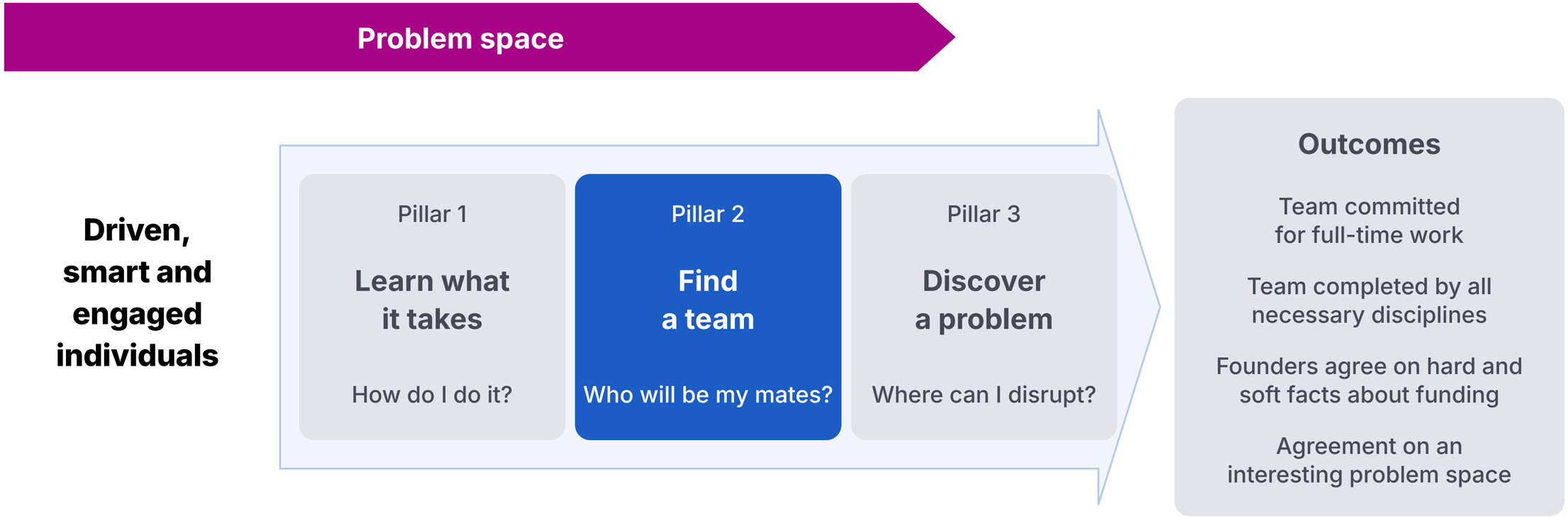
Previously on Ambitious Entrepreneurship

Two pictures from earlier sessions that you need today, then today's question.

01 **Previously on Ambitious Entrepreneurship**
02 Your presentations
03 **Expect it: a brief history of failure**
04 **See it: my story**
05 **Feel it: prepare to be alone**
06 Your turn
07 **Carry it: lessons from 20+ founders**
08 **Close it: when it's over**
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PREVIOUSLY · TEAM (M01)

Your team wrote down how it works



PREVIOUSLY · PRODUCT MANAGEMENT (M10)

Your funnel now feeds one number

IMPRESSIONS
- Always be posting
- Improve your targeting
- Improve your relevance

Tool: **Posting & outreach**

CLICKS
- Farm your friends & family
- Guide through keynotes & presentations

Tool: **Keep the flywheel going**

SIGN-UPS
- Demos, interviews, ...
- Personal interaction

Tool: **Interviewing techniques**

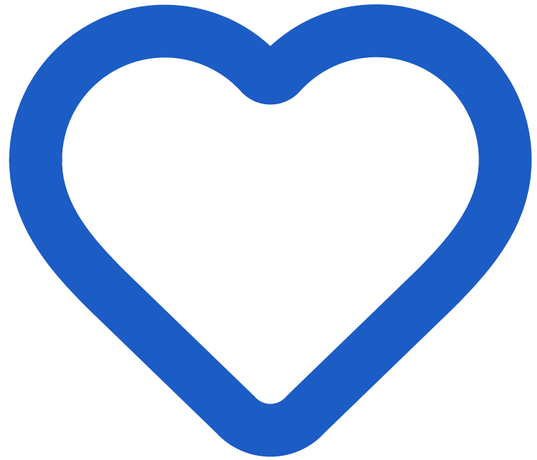
CUSTOMERS
- Show attention
- Manage your funnel
- Be their concierge

Tool: **Managing your funnel**

TODAY'S QUESTION · THINK, DON'T ANSWER

How do you build a company without breaking yourself?

1:00



CHAPTER 2 OF 12

Your presentations

Your venture's numbers in three minutes per team, and how you are stays out.

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YOUR PRESENTATIONS · MAKE IT CREDIBLE

Show us where you're at in 3 minutes or less!

3:00

Facts

Statistics or research

North Star and its drivers, build or grow, Now bets

12 Numbers

Usage or surveys

Revenue against €1,000 and €3,000, back in 14 days, lost, kill line

Quotes

Interviews

Why one customer left, why one stays

Images

Screenshots or users

KPI Tracker, cropped, no customer data

The bets: expected effect against what happened, and one no you sent

What did you do? **What did you learn?** **How can we help?**

Photos on Pixabay: lil_foot_, 6689062, Surprising_Media, tranmautritam.

INPUT 1 OF 6 · CHAPTER 3 OF 12

Expect it: a brief history of failure

Most startups fail, mistakes come with trying, and the process is known.

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INPUT 1 OF 6 · EXPECT IT · THREE QUESTIONS

Why do so many startups fail?

1

Why do startups fail?

2

Can you avoid mistakes?

3

Does knowing the process protect you?

> I can accept failure. Everyone fails at something. But I can't accept not trying.

Michael Jordan

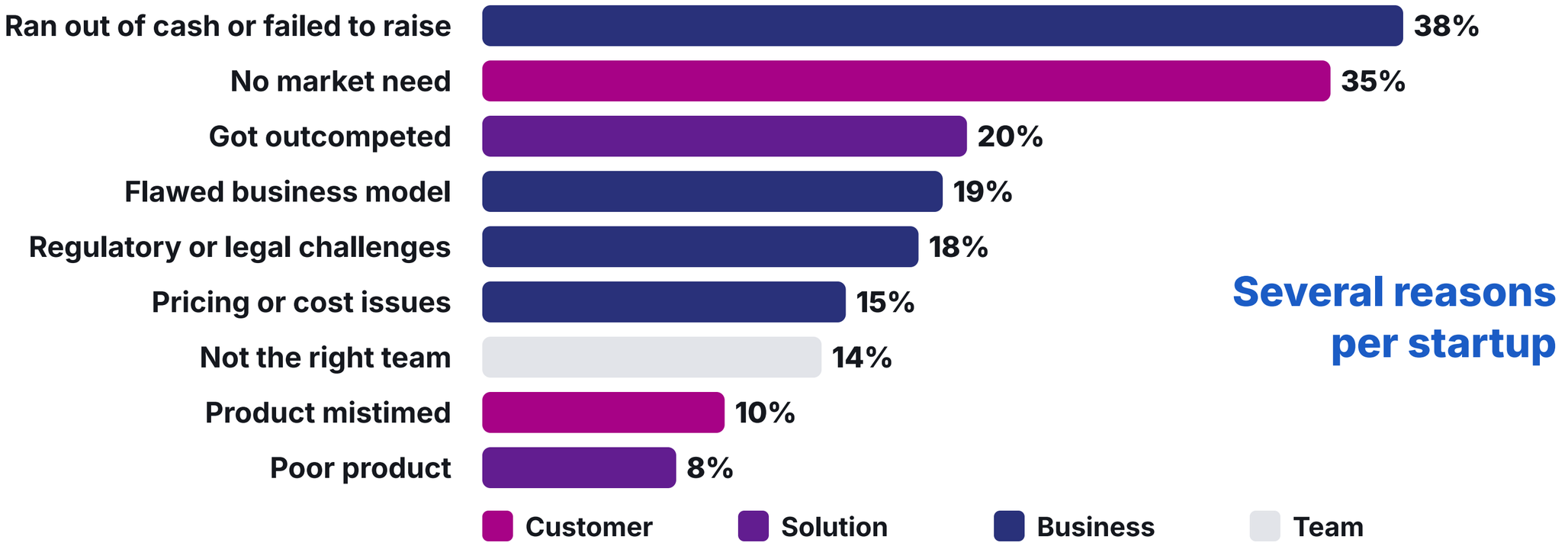


Jordan, M. (1994). I can't accept not trying. HarperSanFrancisco, p. 129, as Wikiquote gives it. Photo: tortugamediaservices on Pixabay.

WHY DO STARTUPS FAIL?

Startups rarely die of one thing

% of 111 post-mortems since 2018 naming each reason, coloured by area



DATA CB Insights, "The top 12 reasons startups fail", 3 August 2021, 111 post-mortems, top 9 of 12 shown. Colours are the course's grouping.

WHY DO STARTUPS FAIL?

It's always a people problem

And then there is timing

> **"No matter how it looks at first, it's always a people problem."**
>
> **Gerald Weinberg**

> **"Timing is the major variable. It's the major form of entrepreneurial risk … maybe by a wide margin."**
>
> **Marc Andreessen**

FRAMEWORK Weinberg, G. M. (1985). The secrets of consulting, the second law of consulting. Marc Andreessen on Masters of Scale, "The 6 secrets of great timing" (podcast, transcript).

Mistakes aren't a necessary evil. They aren't evil at all. They are an inevitable consequence of doing something new.

Ed Catmull, co-founder of **Pixar**



BOOK

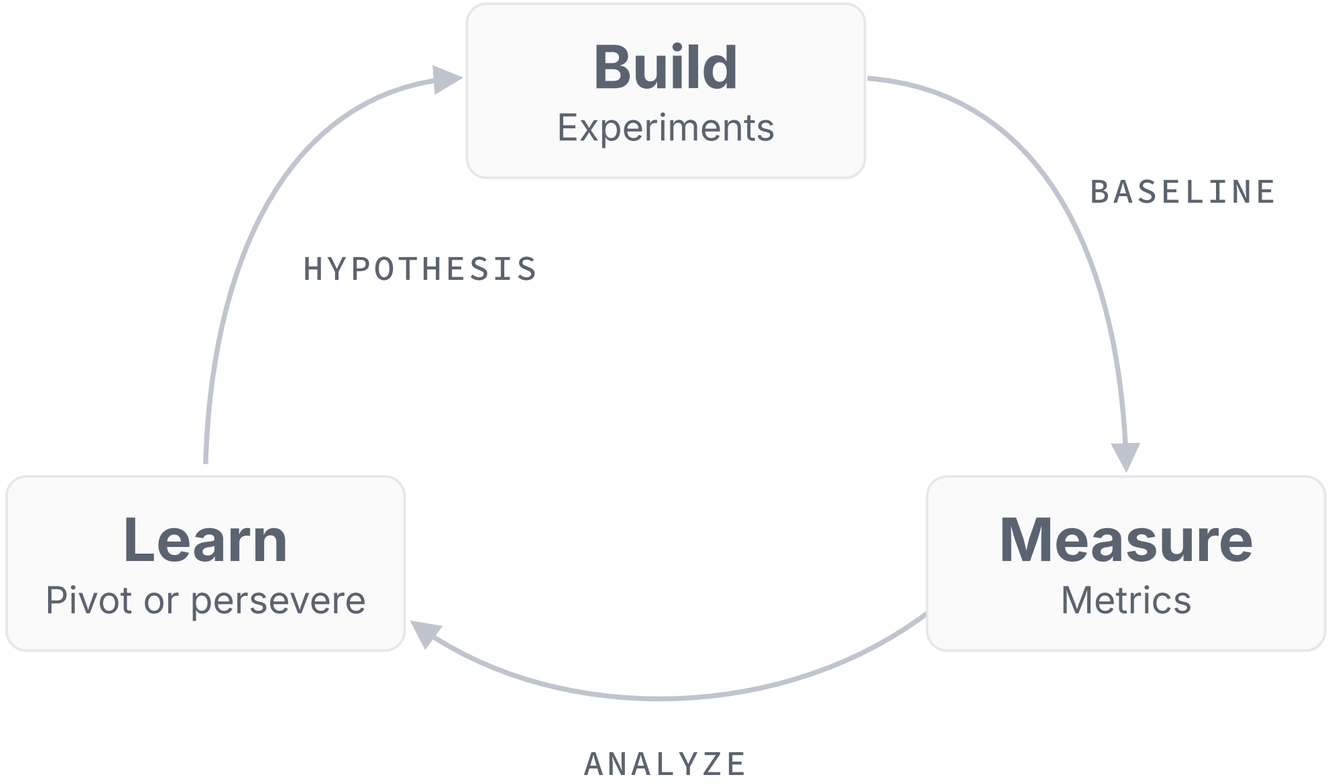
Creativity, Inc.

Ed Catmull with Amy Wallace, 2014

FRAMEWORK Catmull, E., & Wallace, A. (2014). *Creativity, Inc.* Random House, as quoted by Popova (2014), The Marginalian. Photo: RaniRamli on Pixabay, a stock desk lamp, not a Pixar image.

THE PROCESS IS KNOWN · RE-SHOWN

Commitment is risky



THE PROCESS IS KNOWN

24 steps, all written down

Each step is Build-Measure-Learn. Steps 20 and 21 meet reality

1 Market segmentation	**2** Select a beachhead market	**3** Build an end user profile	**4** TAM for the beachhead	**5** Persona for the beachhead	**6** Full life cycle use case
7 High-level product specification	**8** Quantify the value proposition	**9** Identify your next 10 customers	**10** Define your core	**11** Chart your competitive position	**12** Determine the customer organisation
13 Map how to acquire a paying customer	**14** TAM for follow-on markets	**15** Design a business model	**16** Set your pricing framework	**17** Calculate the unit economics	**18** Map the sales process
19 Calculate the customer economics	**20** Identify key assumptions	**21** Test key assumptions	**22** Define the MVP	**23** Prove your beachhead with your MVP	**24** Develop a product plan

FRAMEWORK Aulet, B. (2013). *Disciplined Entrepreneurship: 24 Steps to a Successful Startup*. Wiley. Step names, shortened.

QUICK GUESS · HANDS

What share of founders show signs of strain?

<33%
under a third

~50%
about half

>67%
more than two thirds

1:00



of founders show signs of mental health strain



DATA Richardson, C. (2024). Fuelling founder resilience. Founder Resilience Research Report 2024. Foundology with UCL School of Management. Nearly 400 founders, self-selected, not peer reviewed. Photo: Pexels on Pixabay.

AND STILL

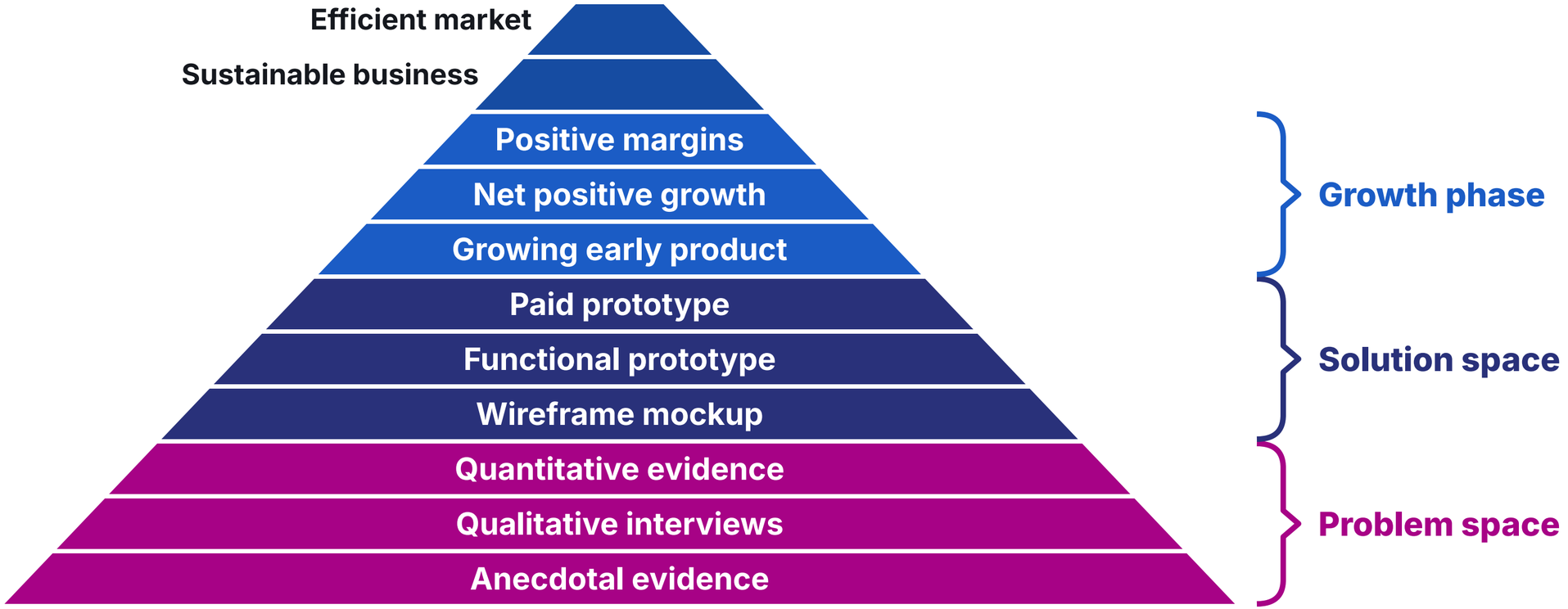


of founders remain glad to be entrepreneurs

DATA Richardson, C. (2024). Fuelling founder resilience. Founder Resilience Research Report 2024. Foundology with UCL School of Management. Nearly 400 founders, self-selected, not peer reviewed.

THE PROCESS IS KNOWN · RE-SHOWN

Climb the evidence, rung by rung



INPUT 1 OF 6 · EXPECT IT · THE ANSWERS

Expect it: failure comes with trying

1

Why do startups fail?

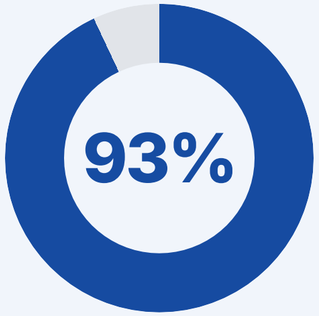
Rarely of one thing, and in the end it's always a people problem

2

Can you avoid mistakes?

No. They are the inevitable consequence of doing something new

3



Does knowing the process protect you?

No. It's all just theory, 93% of founders still show strain

INPUT 2 OF 6 · CHAPTER 4 OF 12

See it: my story

My own startup, blik, from start to finish, in five sentences.

01 ~~Previously on Ambitious Entrepreneurship~~
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INPUT 2 OF 6 · SEE IT · THREE QUESTIONS

What does failing look like from inside?

1

What did we set out to do?

2

What happened instead?

3

What kept us going?

MY STORY

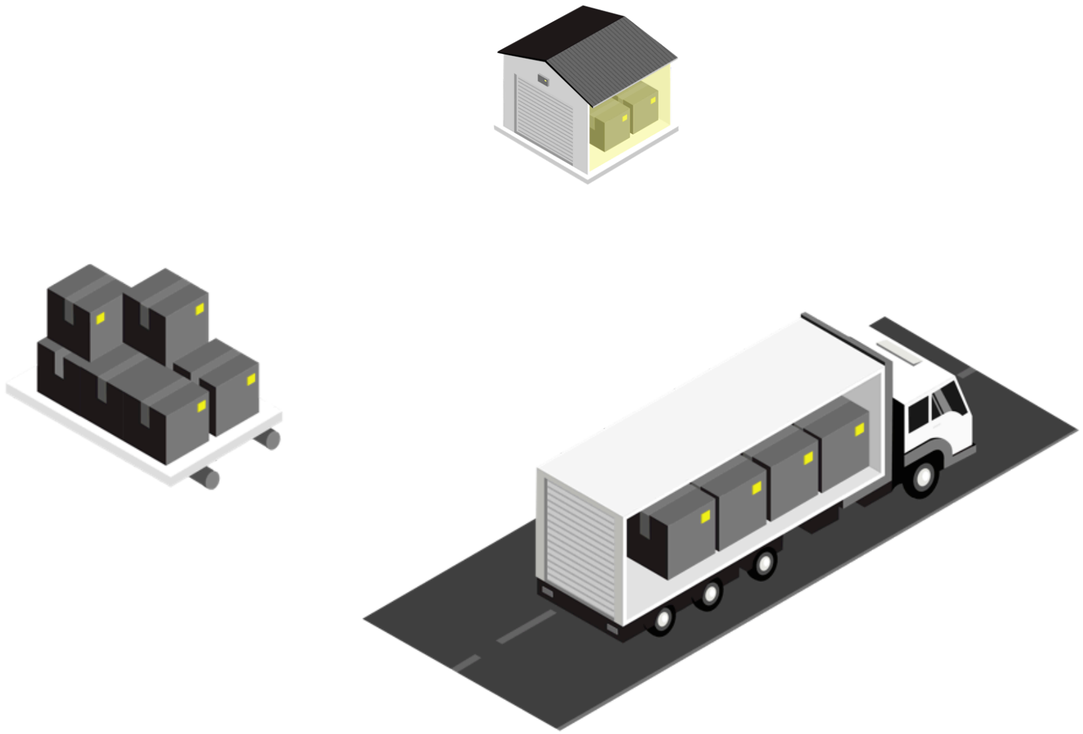
All just **theory**

until it is your startup

MY STORY

What is blik?

blik

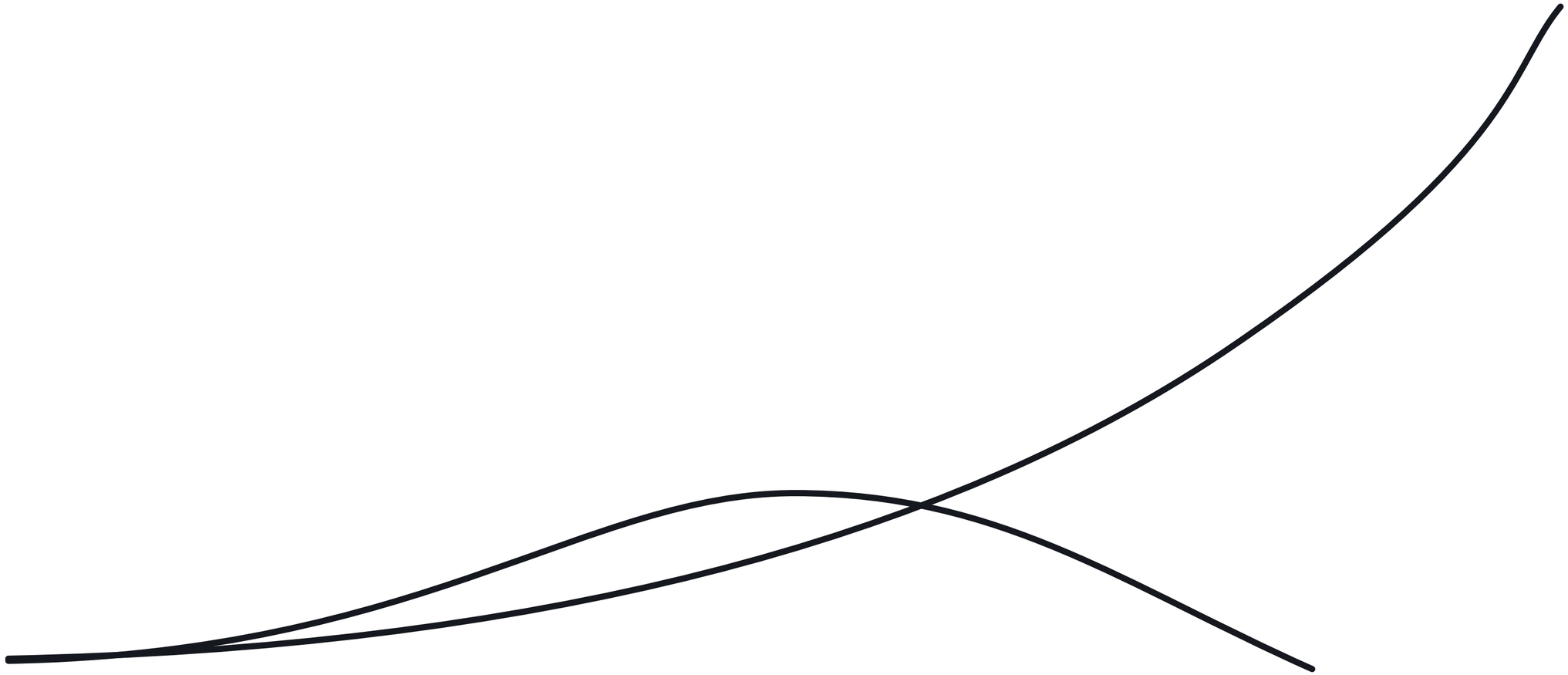



STILL

MY STORY · BLIK

Let's **succeed** or **fail quickly!**

MY STORY · BLIK

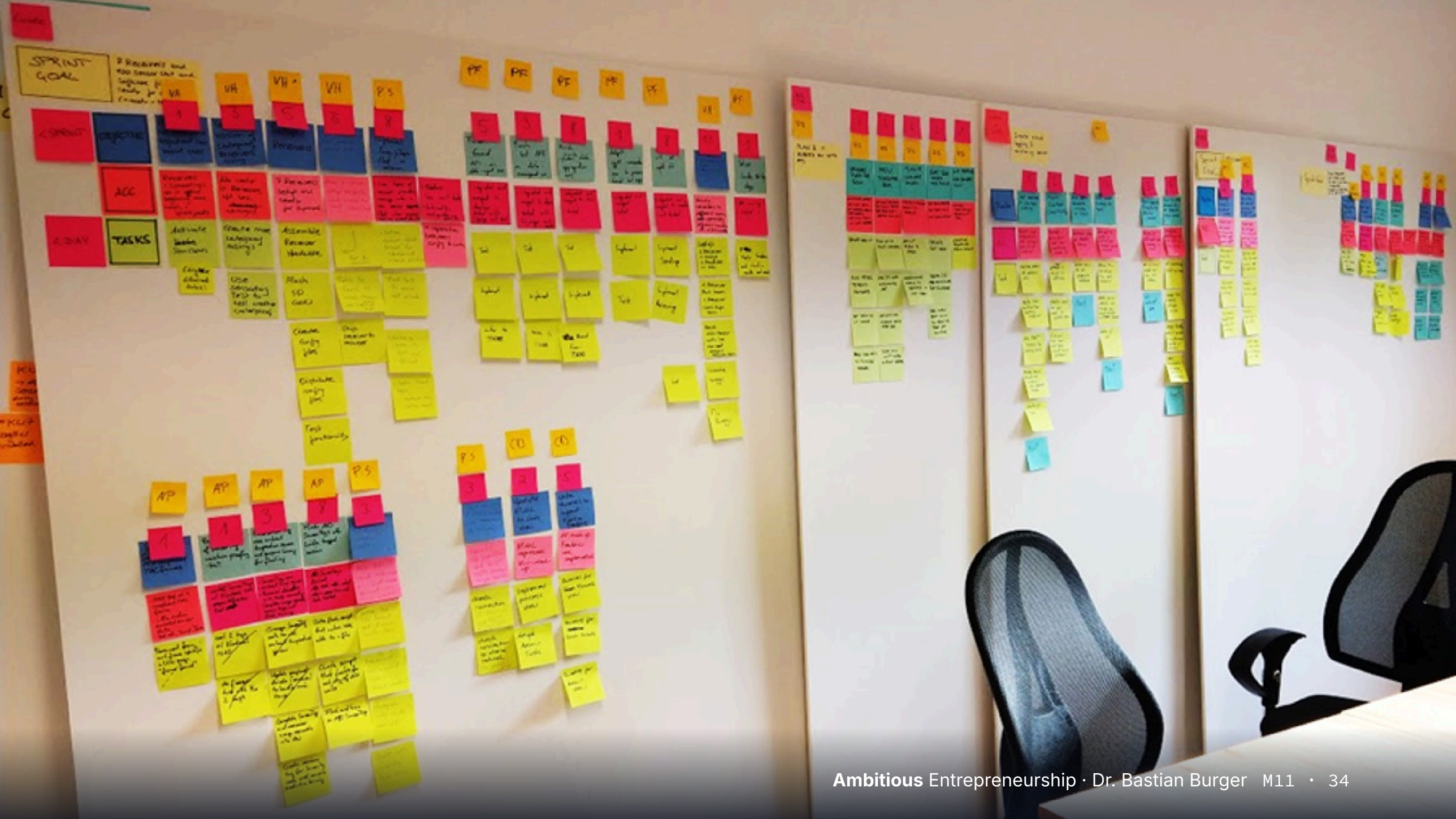


MY STORY · BLIK

"One of the **most promising** startups of the year!"

TechCrunch Runner-up, Startup Battlefield, Disrupt Berlin 2017

The quote is TechCrunch's as I remember it. The event is in Dillet, R. (2017), And the winner of Startup Battlefield at Disrupt Berlin 2017 is... Lia Diagnostics, TechCrunch. Logos are trademarks of their owners.


SPRINT GOAL
ACC
TASKS




01-002-0011

MY STORY · BLIK

It always takes **twice as long** and **costs twice as much** as you think.

MY STORY · BLIK

Let's build something our customers will love!
The next big deal is **just around the corner**.


01-003-0025
01-003-0027
01-003-0029
01-003-002A
01-003-002B
01-003-002D
01-003-002E
01-003-0030
01-003-0031
01-003-0032
01-003-0033
01-003-0035
01-003-0036
01-003-0038
01-003-0039
01-003-003B
01-003-003D
01-003-003E
01-003-003F
01-003-0041
01-003-0042
01-003-0043
01-003-0045
01-003-0046
01-003-0049
01-003-004A
01-003-004B
01-003-004C
01-003-004D
01-003-004E
01-003-004F
01-003-0051
01-003-0052
01-003-0053
01-003-0054
01-003-0056
01-003-0058
01-003-0059
01-003-0057
01-003-005A

When will we build something our customers will love?
The next big deal is **still** around the corner.





INPUT 2 OF 6 · SEE IT · THE ANSWERS

See it: the next big deal was always around the corner

1

What did we set out to do?

Succeed or fail quickly

2

What happened instead?

It always takes twice as long and costs twice as much as you think

3

What kept us going?

The next big deal was always just around the corner

INPUT 3 OF 6 · CHAPTER 5 OF 12

Feel it: prepare to be alone

Why founding is this stressful, how it feels, and why failure hurts for real.

01 ~~Previously on Ambitious Entrepreneurship~~
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INPUT 3 OF 6 · FEEL IT · THREE QUESTIONS

Why does it hurt this much?

1

Why is founding so lonely?

2

Why does failure hurt so much?

3

Where does your stress come from?

PREPARE TO BE ALONE



of founders feel lonely



DATA Richardson, C. (2024). Fuelling founder resilience. Foundology with UCL School of Management. The report compares it with CEOs generally, 50% more.
Photo: harutmovsisyan on Pixabay.

PREPARE TO BE ALONE

Some decisions you make alone

Sooner or later, every founder makes these

Tell it like it is

Lay people off

Demote loyal friends

Bet the company

Step back, step down

...



FRAMEWORK Horowitz, B. (2014). The hard thing about hard things. HarperCollins. Altman, S. (2014). Lecture 2, Team and execution. How to Start a Startup, Y Combinator. Photo: Pexels on Pixabay.

PREPARE TO BE ALONE

Take care of YOU first

In that order.



FRAMEWORK Adapted from Horowitz, B. (2014). *The hard thing about hard things*. HarperCollins.

PREPARE TO BE ALONE · THINK, ALONE

How does it **feel**?



here can we go from here? What can we do now? How can we be successf
eed to do? How did we end up here? What did we do wrong? Why is this not
e doing good work? What are we missing? Where can we go from here? Wh
ow? How can we be successful? What do we need to do? How did we end u
d we do wrong? Why is this not working? Are we doing good work? What a
here can we go from here? What can we do now? How can we be successf
eed to do? How did we end up here? What did we do wrong? Why is this not
e doing good work? What are we missing? Where can we go from here? Wh
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eed to do? How did we end up here? What did we do wrong? Why is this not

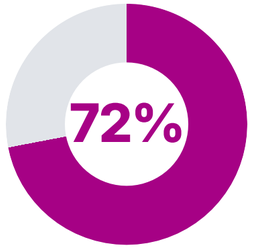


WHAT RESEARCH SAYS

Founding is stressful, and often satisfying

One study finds more strain. A meta-analysis of 94 studies finds a little more satisfaction

ONE US STUDY, 242 FOUNDERS, 93 OTHERS



of the founders were affected by a mental health condition, their own or their family's

Reported a lifetime condition, % of each group



94 STUDIES, 82 COUNTRIES

More positive wellbeing than employees. Effect size 0.12, small, about 790,000 people

Same ill-being. Where the rule of law is weak, founders fare worse

RESEARCH Freeman, Staudenmaier, Zisser and Andresen (2019), Small Business Economics, self-report, the comparison group was younger. Stephan, Rauch and Hatak (2023), Entrepreneurship Theory and Practice. Effect size is Cohen's d.

WHY FAILURE HURTS

This is real, not weakness



Rejection lights up the pain network

Exclusion activates a region that physical pain does



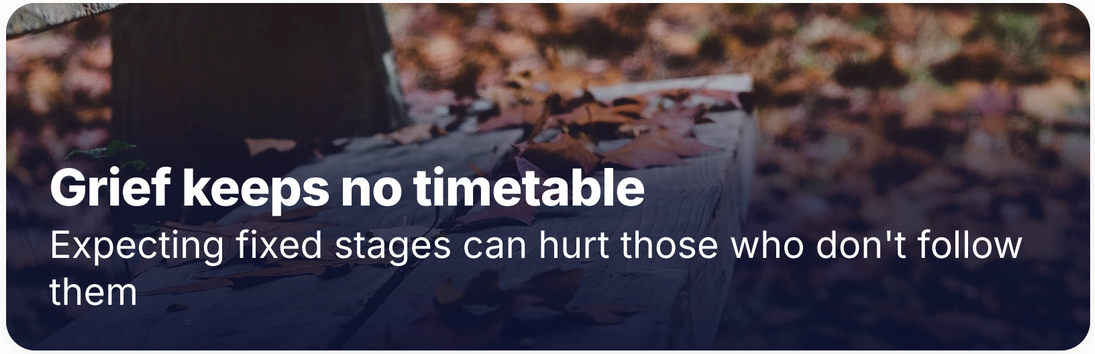
All your worth in one basket

When "I am my startup", its failure feels like yours



Replaying it makes it last longer

Rumination keeps a low mood going



Grief keeps no timetable

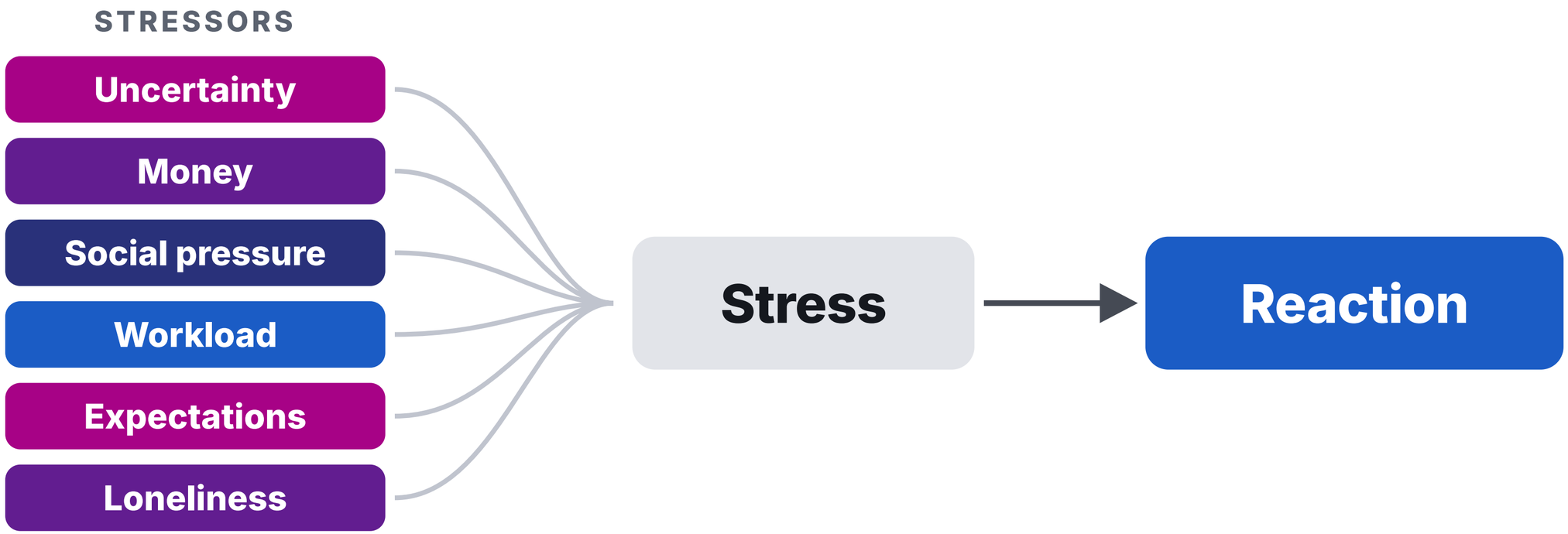
Expecting fixed stages can hurt those who don't follow them

RESEARCH Eisenberger, Lieberman and Williams (2003), Science, 13 people in a scanner. Crocker and Wolfe (2001), Psychological Review, a theory paper. Nolen-Hoeksema (1991), Journal of Abnormal Psychology, a review. Stroebe, Schut and Boerner (2017), OMEGA, a review. Photos on Pixabay: Mitrey, varintorn, RuslanSikunov, AnnieSpratt.

UNDERSTANDING DISTRESS

Know where your stress comes from

Stressor, stress, reaction. For founders, six sources

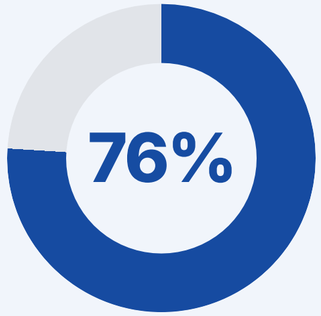


Loneliness added by the course from the 76%. Related research: Wach et al. (2021), Journal of Business Venturing, a diary study of 55 founders. Fernet et al. (2016), loneliness links founder stress to burnout.

INPUT 3 OF 6 · FEEL IT · THE ANSWERS

Feel it: lonely, painful and real

1



Why is founding so lonely?

76% of founders feel lonely, and some decisions you make alone

2

Why does failure hurt so much?

Rejection activates a region physical pain does. It is real, not weakness

3

Where does your stress come from?

Six sources. Uncertainty, money, social pressure, workload, expectations, loneliness

CHAPTER 6 OF 12

Your turn: you and failure

Ten minutes about you and failure, alone, in pairs, then two voices for the room.

01 ~~Previously on Ambitious Entrepreneurship~~
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YOUR TURN · 10 MINUTES

You and failure

1. The last time I failed at something I cared about, **what did I tell myself?**
2. When things go wrong, **what's my first reflex?**
   hide · push harder · blame · analyse · talk to someone
3. If my startup failed next year, **what would still be me?**

4 min
Alone, write it down

3 min
In pairs, share one answer

3 min
Two voices for the room

10:00

INPUT 4 OF 6 · CHAPTER 7 OF 12

Carry it: lessons from 20+ founders

What founders told me about looking after yourself and your co-founder.

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INPUT 4 OF 6 · CARRY IT · THREE QUESTIONS

How do you last?

1

Who are you without your startup?

2

What helps you recover?

3

How do you look after your co-founder?

LESSONS FROM 20+ FOUNDERS · 1 OF 2



Taking care of **yourself**

as a founder

TAKING CARE OF YOURSELF

"I am CEO and Co-Founder of my startup."

The big box is the identity you give yourself. Nothing else counts



TAKING CARE OF YOURSELF

"Who am I?"

The startup is gone, and the 90% with it. Only the small rest is left



FROM EXTERNAL TO INTERNAL SELF

Relabel it to what survives failure

An entrepreneur sometimes fails, and stays an entrepreneur

HELLO, I AM

the founder of Startup XY

↘ The startup fails

Who am I?

HELLO, I AM

an entrepreneur

↘ The startup fails

HELLO, I AM

an entrepreneur

"The startup failed", not "I am a failure"

FROM EXTERNAL TO INTERNAL SELF · THINK, ALONE

Who would you be without the labels?

If there were **no** **Instagram** **and no** **LinkedIn**, who would you like to be?

If there were **no one to impress**, no one to judge you, what would you do?

If you had **none of your achievements** to show, how would you describe yourself?

Logos are trademarks of their owners.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS, PER PRACTICE

Real effects, mostly small. Keep one



Walking or jogging, in people with depression

Effect size 0.62, moderate, low certainty. 218 trials



After a good night, founders judged new ideas better

3 studies with founders



An evening note on what weighs on you helps, a little

Effect size 0.075, small. 146 trials



Lifts well-being a little, no more than other good exercises

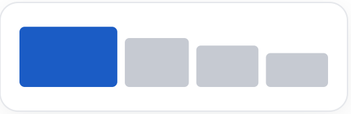
Effect size 0.17, small



Eases anxiety and depression a little

Effect sizes 0.38 and 0.30 at 8 weeks. 47 trials

RESEARCH Noetel et al. (2024), 14,170 people with major depression. Gish et al. (2019). Frattaroli (2006). Davis et al. (2016). Goyal et al. (2014). Effect sizes as reported (Hedges' g, r, Cohen's d), not comparable one to one. Photos on Pixabay: Michael_Pointner, WOKANDAPIX, AV_Photographer, GingerQuip, dimitrisvetsikas1969.



TAKING CARE OF YOURSELF

You are **not your work!**

LESSONS FROM 20+ FOUNDERS · 2 OF 2

Taking care of your **co-founder**

as a relationship



TAKING CARE OF YOUR CO-FOUNDER

Talk about these five early

It's always tough with your co-founders, so talk before it gets tough

- Needs
- Values
- Expectations
- Communication style
- Energy

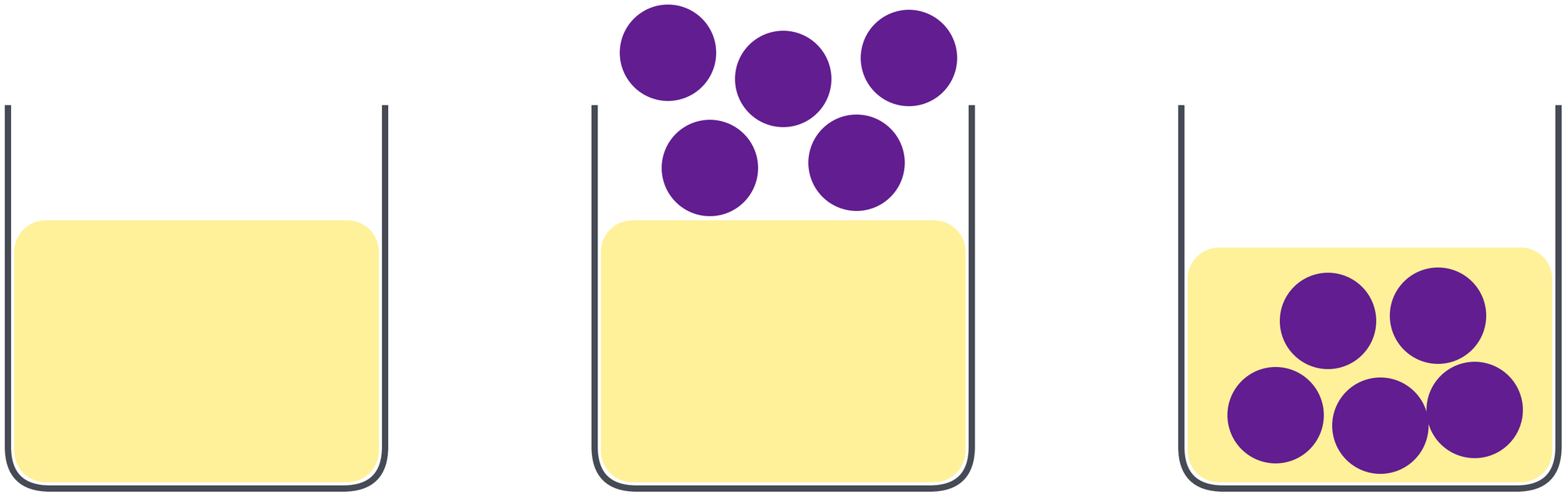
Four of them come down to communication

> "All good?" "All good." is not that talk. Both say how they really are.

TAKING CARE OF YOUR CO-FOUNDER · THE PACE

Pack the scary bits first

Otherwise they won't fit



1 · Sand first
the small stuff

2 · Then the rocks
they won’t fit

3 · Rocks first
the sand fills the gaps

QUICK ASK · HANDS

What is your team's biggest rock before Demo Day?

1:00

INPUT 4 OF 6 · CARRY IT · THE ANSWERS

Carry it: you are not your work

1

Who are you without your startup?

An entrepreneur, whatever this startup does. You are not your work

2

What helps you recover?

One practice you keep. The effects are real, mostly small

3

How do you look after your co-founder?

Talk early and honestly, and pack the scary bits first

INPUT 5 OF 6 · CHAPTER 8 OF 12

Close it: when it's over

If it comes to that, close the company in the right order and leave no grudge.

01 ~~Previously on Ambitious Entrepreneurship~~
02 ~~Your presentations~~
03 ~~Expect it: a brief history of failure~~
04 ~~See it: my story~~
05 ~~Feel it: prepare to be alone~~
06 ~~Your turn~~
07 ~~Carry it: lessons from 20+ founders~~
08 **Close it: when it's over**
09 **Own it: not one single regret**
10 Wrap-up and fireside
11 Workshop: the energy audit
12 Case discussion

INPUT 5 OF 6 · CLOSE IT · THREE QUESTIONS

If you close, what comes first?

1

What do you do on the day you decide?

2

What must you know in Germany?

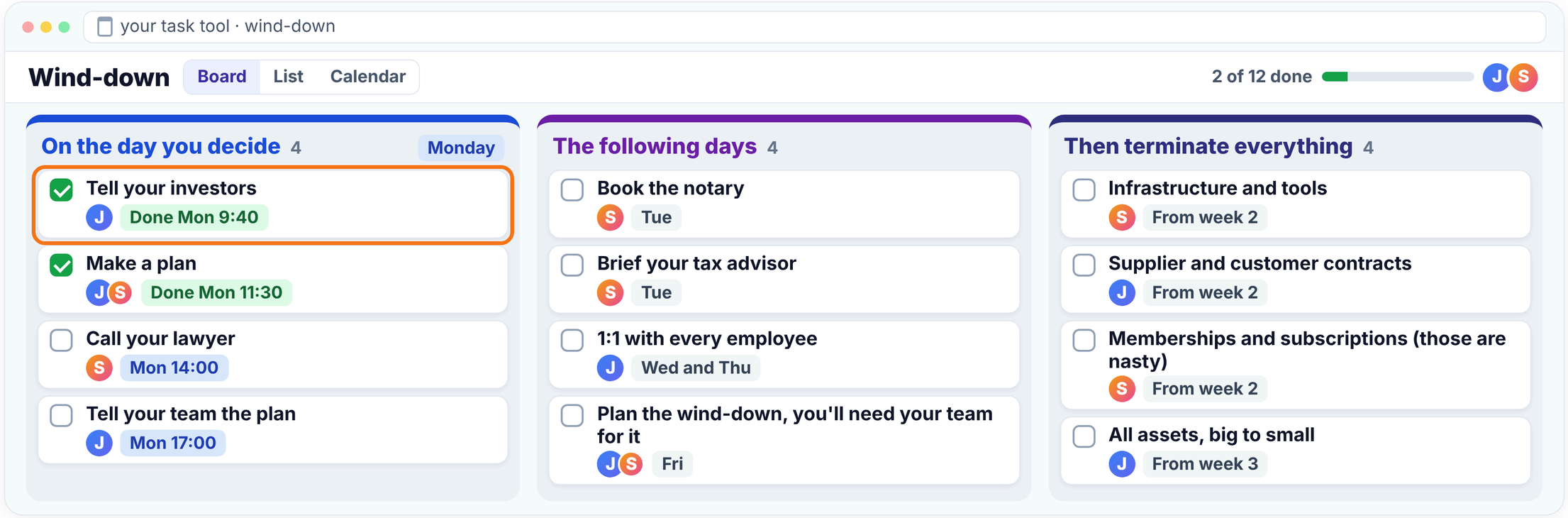
3

How do you face disappointed investors?

WHEN IT'S OVER

Investors first, on day one

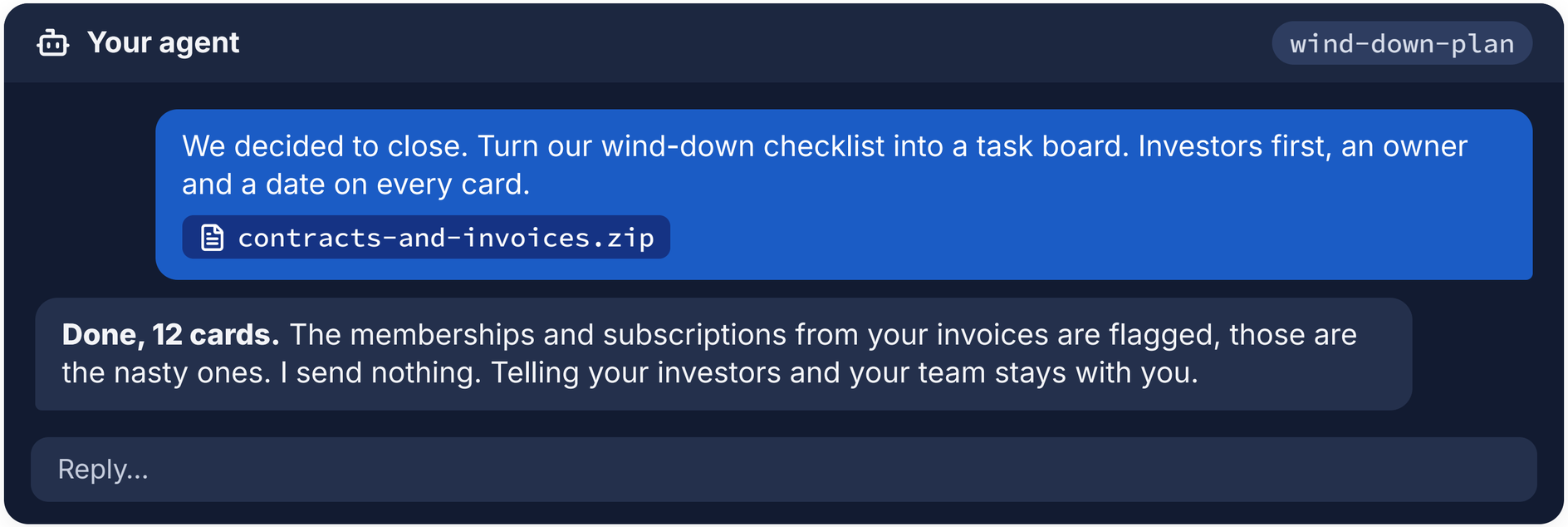
A wind-down checklist



ILLUSTRATIVE A wind-down checklist, condensed, on a made-up team's task board. Screen and chat prototyped for this course.

WITH YOUR AGENT

Investors first, on day one



ILLUSTRATIVE A wind-down checklist, condensed, on a made-up team's task board. Screen and chat prototyped for this course.

WHEN IT'S OVER · GERMANY, GMBH OR UG

Four rules to know before you close

Orientation only, as of 2026. Not legal advice

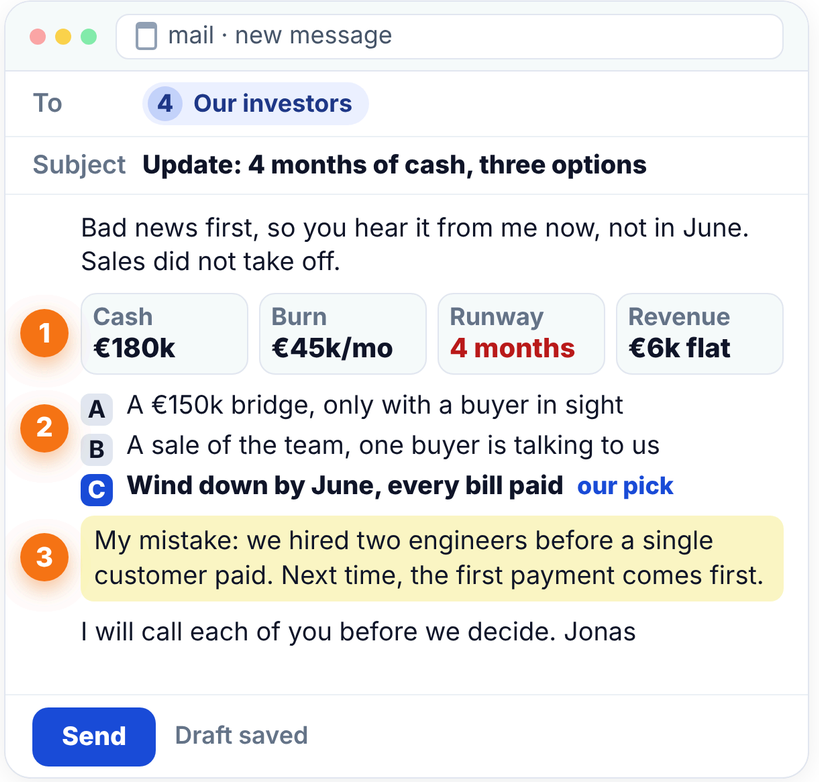
⚠ **Insolvent?**	File without delay, at the latest 3 weeks after illiquidity, 6 weeks after over-indebtedness. Waiting longer is a crime.	§15a InsO
⚖ **Solvent?**	Liquidation takes a year at least. After the public call to creditors, the blocking year runs before anything goes back to shareholders.	§73 GmbHG
Afterwards	Someone keeps the books for 10 years, often a founder.	§74 GmbHG
Job ends?	Register as job-seeking at least 3 months before the job ends, or within 3 days of knowing. Your team too.	§38 SGB III

DATA German law as of 20 October 2026, gesetze-im-internet.de, §15a InsO, §73, §65 and §74 GmbHG, §38 and §159 SGB III. Orientation only, not legal advice.

WHEN IT'S OVER

Facing disappointed investors, no surprises

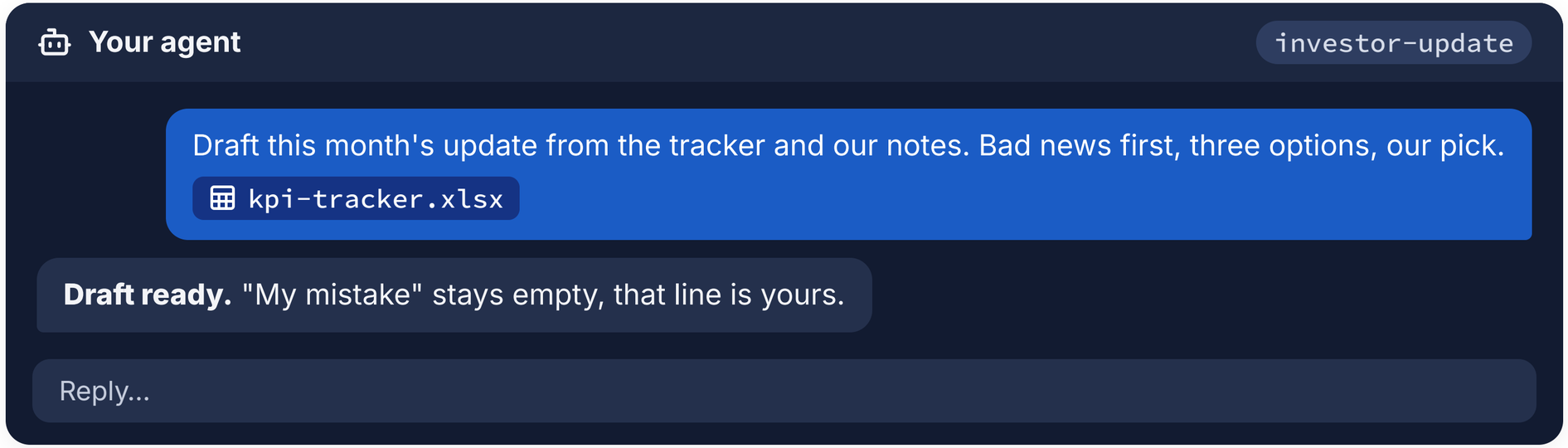
1. **No surprises.** Share bad news early, in writing, with numbers. Keep the updates coming when it gets bad.
2. **Bring options,** not just the problem. Bridge, pivot, sale or acqui-hire, orderly wind-down, plus your recommendation.
3. **Own it.** No blame, no spin. Say what you would do differently.
4. **Close the loop.** A final update. What happened, what's left and who gets it, where the team landed. Then say thank you.
5. **Know their math.** About 3 in 4 US venture-backed startups don't return investors' capital, by Ghosh's count. Pros expect losses, not surprises. Angels, friends and family, call them personally.



ILLUSTRATIVE Rule 5, Gage, D. (2012, 20 September). The venture capital secret. 3 out of 4 start-ups fail. The Wall Street Journal, on Shikhar Ghosh's research. Email and chat made up, prototyped for this course.

WITH YOUR AGENT

Facing disappointed investors, no surprises



ILLUSTRATIVE Rule 5, Gage, D. (2012, 20 September). The venture capital secret. 3 out of 4 start-ups fail. The Wall Street Journal, on Shikhar Ghosh's research. Email and chat made up, prototyped for this course.



of founders show signs of mental health strain



DATA Richardson, C. (2024). Fuelling founder resilience. Founder Resilience Research Report 2024. Foundology with UCL School of Management. Nearly 400 founders, self-selected, not peer reviewed. Photo: Pexels on Pixabay.

AND STILL



of founders remain glad to be entrepreneurs

DATA Richardson, C. (2024). Fuelling founder resilience. Founder Resilience Research Report 2024. Foundology with UCL School of Management. Nearly 400 founders, self-selected, not peer reviewed.

INPUT 5 OF 6 · CLOSE IT · THE ANSWERS

Close it: investors first, no surprises

1

What do you do on the day you decide?

Tell your investors first, make a plan, call your lawyer, tell your team

2

What must you know in Germany?

Insolvent? File without delay. Solvent? Liquidation takes at least a year

3

How do you face disappointed investors?

No surprises. Bad news early, in writing, with numbers and options

INPUT 6 OF 6 · CHAPTER 9 OF 12

Own it: not one single regret

What founders who failed shared with me, and the advice I give.

01 ~~Previously on Ambitious Entrepreneurship~~
02 ~~Your presentations~~
03 ~~Expect it: a brief history of failure~~
04 ~~See it: my story~~
05 ~~Feel it: prepare to be alone~~
06 ~~Your turn~~
07 ~~Carry it: lessons from 20+ founders~~
08 ~~Close it: when it's over~~
09 **Own it: not one single regret**
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INPUT 6 OF 6 · OWN IT · THREE QUESTIONS

Was it worth it?

1

Do founders who failed regret it?

2

What did they all find?

3

What is my advice?

NOT ONE SINGLE REGRET

Shared insights: you don't get it until you have been there

You don't get it until you have been there

It's a learning journey nobody regrets

It's always tough with your co-founders

In the end, it was too long

There is always the next big thing around the corner

"Everything is great" is a lie

NOT ONE SINGLE REGRET

My advice: never leave with a grudge

It gets you when you least expect it

Take more time for yourself than you anticipate

Liquidation takes longer than you think

Never leave with a grudge

Don't jump into the next thing

INPUT 6 OF 6 · OWN IT · THE ANSWERS

Own it: a journey nobody regrets

1

Do founders who failed regret it?

No. It's a learning journey nobody regrets

2

What did they all find?

It always took too long, and "everything is great" is a lie

3

What is my advice?

Take more time for yourself than you anticipate. Never leave with a grudge

CHAPTER 10 OF 12

Wrap-up and fireside Q&A

Three sentences to take home, your week, where to get help, then the fireside.

01 ~~Previously on Ambitious Entrepreneurship~~
02 ~~Your presentations~~
03 ~~Expect it: a brief history of failure~~
04 ~~See it: my story~~
05 ~~Feel it: prepare to be alone~~
06 ~~Your turn~~
07 ~~Carry it: lessons from 20+ founders~~
08 ~~Close it: when it's over~~
09 ~~Own it: not one single regret~~
10 **Wrap-up and fireside**
11 Workshop: the energy audit
12 Case discussion

WRAP-UP · HOW DO YOU BUILD A COMPANY WITHOUT BREAKING YOURSELF?

Three things to take home

Say them tomorrow without the slide

I

Most startups fail.

Plan for it, don't fear it.

II

You are not your work.

Diversify your identity.

III

Take care of YOU,

the people, the product, the profits, in that order.

RECAP · PICTURE 1 OF 2

Who are you, besides the startup?

Without it, this is what is left. The white is yours to fill



RECAP · PICTURE 2 OF 2

YOU first, then the people, the product, the profits

In that order.



FRAMEWORK Adapted from Horowitz, B. (2014). *The hard thing about hard things*. HarperCollins.

REFLECTION 1 OF 3 · THE CONTENT

What could you apply?



What could you apply?



What gave you a hard time?

REFLECTION 2 OF 3 · THE PROCESS

Man vs. machine



Where did AI actually help you?



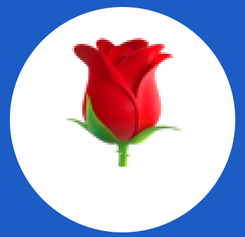
Where was your genius needed?



What are your best hacks to share?

REFLECTION 3 OF 3 · THE RESULTS

Rose, thorn, bud



What was the breakthrough today?



What was the hardest part today?



What is an idea/feature you didn't have time to finish, but want to explore later?

HOMEWORK UNTIL NEXT TIME

Reach €5,000 cumulative revenue from outside your social graph, keep the private maps you chose, of what drains and energises you, for seven days, and hold one honest co-founder conversation that ends in one agreed change in your Team sheet, with a revisit date.

7 days, your map, one conversation

The learning floor is €2,000 cumulative and the conversation with its written change.

Your stop line. "If I catch myself [my sign] twice this week, I tell my co-founder and take the next evening off."

HOMEWORK · HOW TO DO IT

Map it privately, sell daily

The map is an offer. Skip it without a reason

1. **Start or continue your map today,** on paper or in a note only you see. Each stressful moment and its source, then what energises you.
2. **Keep one practice** that research backs. Sleep, exercise, an evening note or gratitude. Not all four.
3. **Pack the scary bits first,** what must happen before Demo Day. Your pipeline founder from Product management (M10) keeps selling every day.
4. **Ask AI for a blind read of your pipeline,** raw notes without names or your hypothesis. Say where it disagrees.

! **Watch out.** Your map never goes into an AI tool or a shared file.

5. **Read your map on day seven.** Your three strongest drains, and why? Tell your team "yes, seven days" or "no".
6. **Draft your pitch, ugly.** Ten slides in Sequoia's order.

HOMEWORK · WHAT YOU COME BACK WITH

Good is kept, said and still selling

	GOOD	WEAK
MAP	Seven days. Late payers drain, customer calls energise	Dropped on day two
TALK	Both said how they are. Sunday off, revisit in four weeks	"All good?" "All good."
PACE	Scary bits first. €2,600 so far	Selling paused "for now"

WHERE TO GET HELP

More than a bad week? Talk to someone

A bad week is normal. More? Talk to someone outside the team



Talk to someone	Your doctor, university counselling or a founder you trust
Germany, now	TelefonSeelsorge 0800 111 0 111 or 0800 111 0 222, free, day and night
Austria · Switzerland	142 · 143
Emergency	112
Elsewhere	findahelpline.com

DATA Official sites as of 20 October 2026, telefonseelsorge.de, telefonseelsorge.at, 143.ch, digital-strategy.ec.europa.eu (112), findahelpline.com. In Switzerland your phone provider may charge a fee. More in the course resource Getting help. Photo: MabelAmber on Pixabay.



Fireside Q&A

Pull your chairs closer. Ask me anything, blik's numbers, investors, what I'd do differently.

Photo: Pexels on Pixabay.

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„Et hätt noch immer jot jejange."

"It always turned out fine." · §3 Rheinisches Grundgesetz

Photo: TB-Photography on Pixabay.

MODULE 11 · FOUNDER HEALTH · WORKSHOP · 90 MINUTES

Workshop: the energy audit

Map what drains you, say how you really are, and plan a week you can hold.

01 Previously on Ambitious Entrepreneurship
02 Your presentations
03 **Expect it: a brief history of failure**
04 **See it: my story**
05 **Feel it: prepare to be alone**
06 Your turn
07 **Carry it: lessons from 20+ founders**
08 **Close it: when it's over**
09 **Own it: not one single regret**
10 Wrap-up and fireside
11 **Workshop: the energy audit**
12 Case discussion

WORKSHOP · BEFORE WE START

Today is personal

Nothing you write is collected or read out

Share what you choose

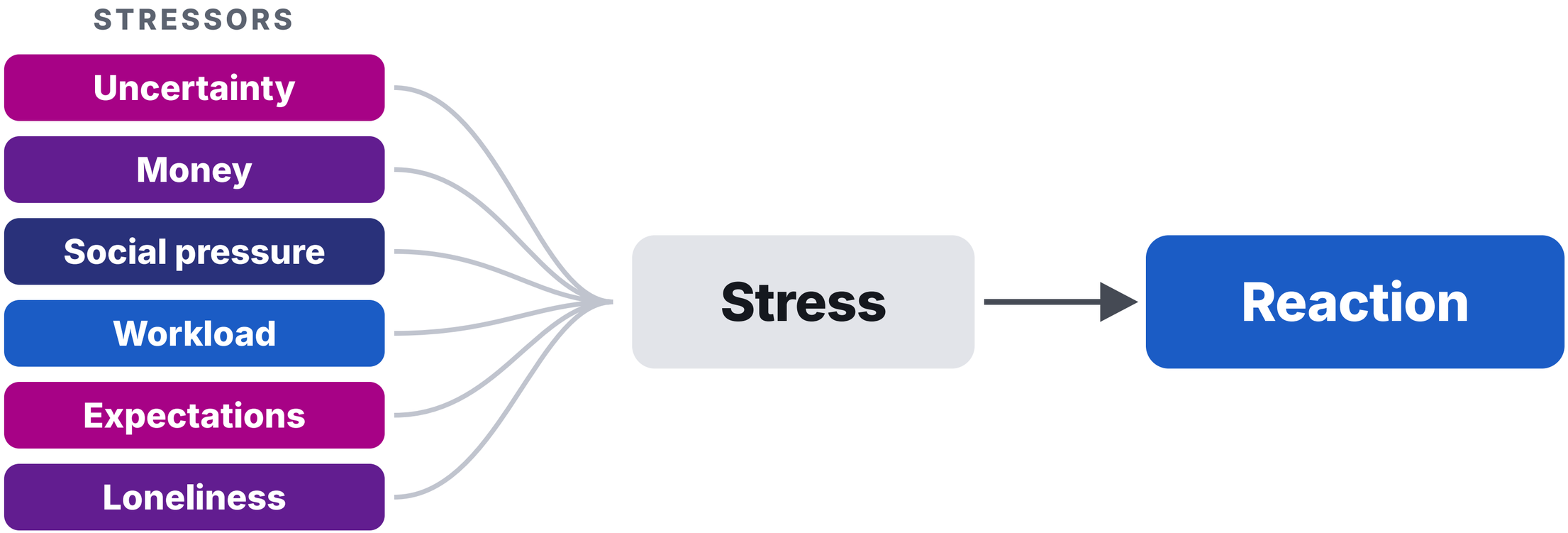
Sit out any step

Where to get help is in the homework

WORKSHOP · THE MAP FOR STEP 1

Know where your stress comes from

Stressor, stress, reaction. For founders, six sources



WORKSHOP · STEP 1 OF 3

Map what drains you

1 STEP 1 · 25 MIN

MAP WHAT DRAINS YOU

Know what drains and energises you. Alone

→ Three questions in writing: what I told myself, my reflex, what stays
→ Map the last two weeks: each stressful moment and its source
→ Map what gave you energy
→ Stop line: a sign others see, how often, what then
→ Pick one practice you keep from today

Output Map, stop line and practice, kept by you **Minutes** 25

Notes

My map On this device · Not shared

DRAINS, THE LAST TWO WEEKS

Money	A late payer, third reminder
Uncertainty	The pilot decision slipped again
Workload	Three nights past 1 am
Social pressure	"When do you get a real job?"
Loneliness	Sunday alone with the numbers

GAVE ME ENERGY

+ A customer: "this saved my Monday"
+ Climbing on Thursday

Stop line. If I go silent twice in 7 days, I tell my co-founder.

Practice. Sleep, phone out of the bedroom.

25:00

ILLUSTRATIVE Founder health (M11) workshop. Note prototyped for this course, made up, nobody's real map.

WORKSHOP · STEP 2 OF 3

Say how you really are

2 STEP 2 · 40 MIN

SAY HOW YOU REALLY ARE

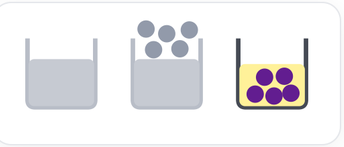
Every founder says how they are. One change

→ Open your Team (M01) agreement in the Team sheet
→ Go round once. Listen, don't fix. Anyone may pass
→ Needs, values, expectations, communication style, energy
→ Agree one change until your next big deadline, with a revisit date
→ Each founder confirms, dated

Output One change in your Team sheet, every founder's yes **Minutes** 40



40:00



WORKSHOP · STEP 3 OF 3

Pack the scary bits first

3 STEP 3 · 25 MIN

PACK THE SCARY BITS FIRST

A week your team can hold that still sells

→ Name what must happen next and keeps slipping
→ Put them in first, each with an owner and a day
→ Write your team line in your new Team sheet row
→ Copy the bar, pick your level, euros by midweek
→ One follow-up each, to a Pipeline lead or a customer's referral

Output Your week, the team line, the bar picked, asks sent

Minutes 25

25:00

ARRIVED EMPTY-HANDED?

Start with the agreement



No Team (M01) agreement? Write its Time and Feedback rows first. Solo? Hold Step 2 with a peer founder or mentor.

WHERE TO GET HELP

More than a bad week? Talk to someone

A bad week is normal. More? Talk to someone outside the team



Talk to someone	Your doctor, university counselling or a founder you trust
Germany, now	TelefonSeelsorge 0800 111 0 111 or 0800 111 0 222, free, day and night
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HOMEWORK UNTIL NEXT TIME

Reach €5,000 cumulative revenue from outside your social graph, keep the private maps you chose, of what drains and energises you, for seven days, and hold one honest co-founder conversation that ends in one agreed change in your Team sheet, with a revisit date.

7 days, your map, one conversation

The learning floor is €2,000 cumulative and the conversation with its written change.

Your stop line. "If I catch myself [my sign] twice this week, I tell my co-founder and take the next evening off."

Look after each other. See you next time!

MODULE 11 · FOUNDER HEALTH · CASE DISCUSSION · ABOUT 90 MINUTES

Case discussion: Pitch

Stand with Christian Reber at the end of 2023 and decide whether he stays as chief executive or steps back.

01 Previously on Ambitious Entrepreneurship
02 Your presentations
03 **Expect it: a brief history of failure**
04 **See it: my story**
05 **Feel it: prepare to be alone**
06 Your turn
07 **Carry it: lessons from 20+ founders**
08 **Close it: when it's over**
09 **Own it: not one single regret**
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11 Workshop: the energy audit
12 **Case discussion**

CASE · PITCH, BERLIN, THE END OF 2023 · VOTE 1 OF 2

Should he stay as Pitch's chief executive, or step back?

Pitch Berlin, the end of 2023

Stay

as chief executive

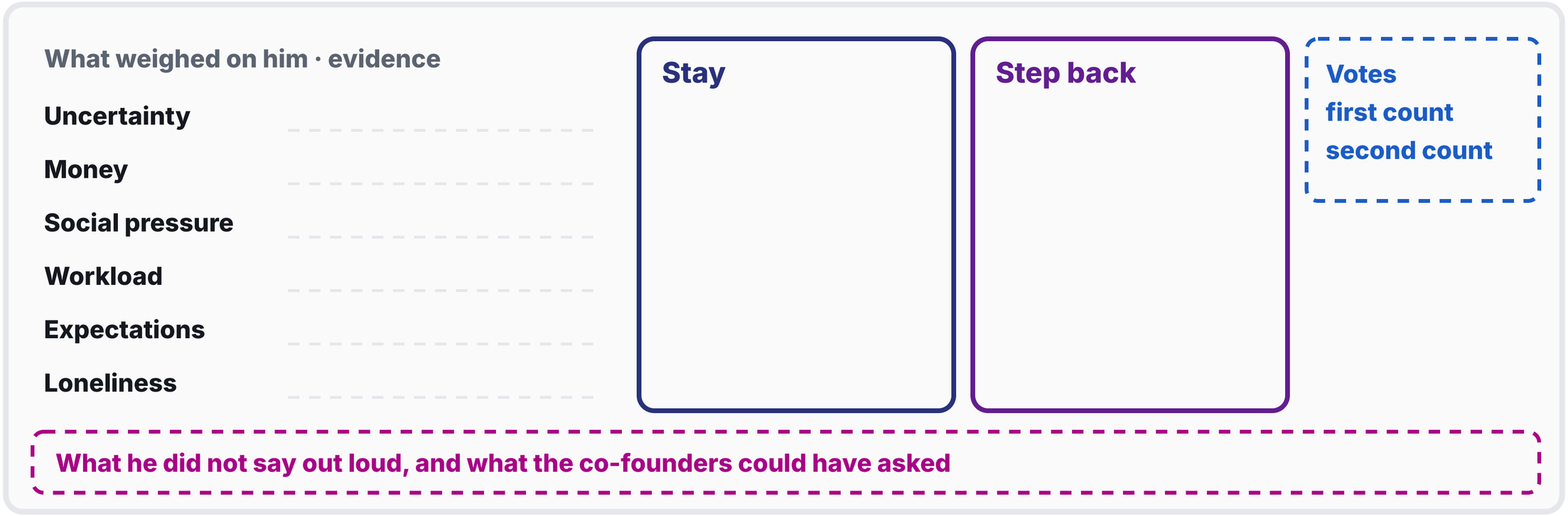
Step back

from the role

DATA Founder health (M11) case: Pitch, "Stay as CEO or Step Back?". The two options as the case's closing states them.

CASE · THE BOARD PLAN

Sources on the left, the two options in the middle



DATA Founder health (M11) case: Pitch, board plan of the case slide brief, section 5.

CASE · WHAT HAPPENED UNTIL THE END OF 2023

Six years of growth, one cut, and a hard year

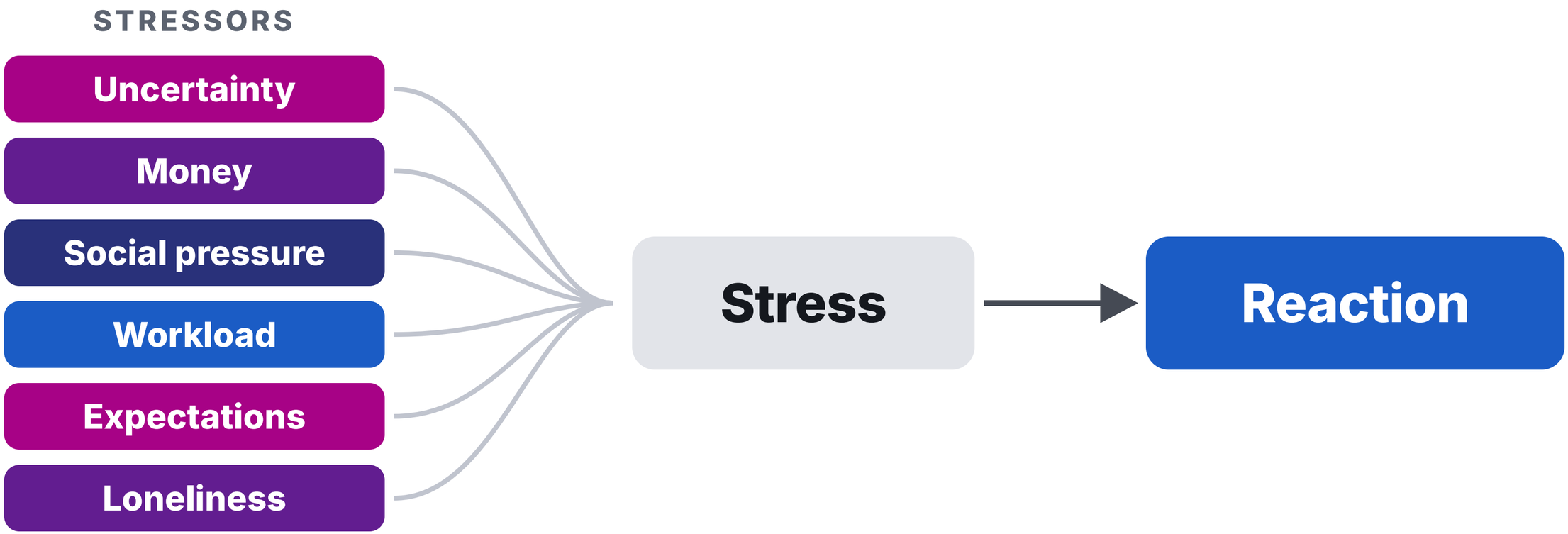


DATA Founder health (M11) case: Pitch, the case text and Exhibits 1 and 2. Nothing after the end of 2023.

CASE · DIAGNOSIS · 30 MINUTES

What weighed on Reber? Sort it by source

Each source needs a quote or an exhibit row from the case



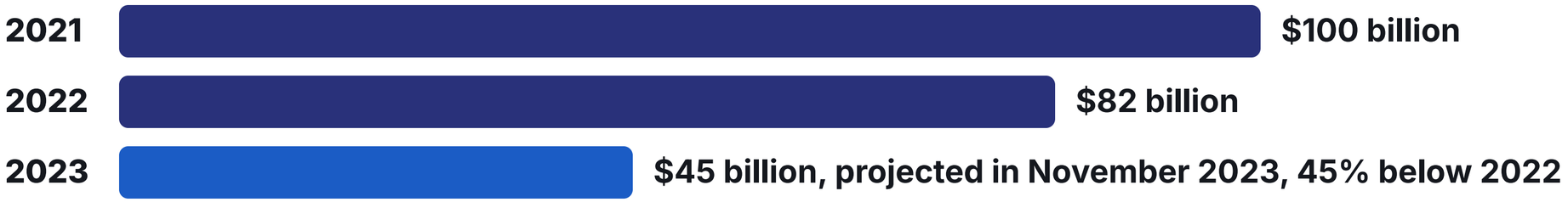
The stressor map of the input session, as the case shows it after its exhibits.

CASE · EXHIBIT 3

The money halved in two years

Atomico and EY measure different things and are not comparable with each other

Venture funding for European tech companies (Atomico)



Investment in German start-ups (EY), 2023: €3.1 billion in the first half, half of the first half of 2022

DATE	WHAT REBER SAID ABOUT RAISING MONEY
Quoted by CNBC, 12 April 2022	**"As a founder who is starting companies more frequently, I feel like it's never been better to raise."**
6 May 2022	**"Fundraising on similar terms between now and 2024 looks unlikely."**

DATA CNBC on Atomico's *State of European Tech* report, 28 November 2023, EY Startup-Barometer, July 2023, CNBC, 12 April 2022, and Reber on LinkedIn, 6 May 2022 (M11 case, Exhibit 3).

CASE · REBER'S CHAIR · 15 MINUTES

What would still be his without the title?



"When you're used to being in a leadership position and you realise it doesn't work any more, everything collapses at once. Like a house of cards."

Christian Reber, recalling 2022, told in 2024

DATA Capital, 3 March 2024, translated from German by the case writer (M11 case, "The Turn"). Photo: ptra on Pixabay.

CASE · THE CO-FOUNDERS' CHAIR · 15 MINUTES

What could they have asked?

> **"I should have answered, 'Shit, honestly, I don't know, this is too much for me.' But I didn't say it out loud."**
>
> Christian Reber, recalling the time after the layoff of September 2022, told in 2024

DATA Capital, 3 March 2024, translated from German by the case writer (M11 case, "The Turn").

CASE · VOTE 2 OF 2

Same question. Who moved, and why?

Stay

as chief executive

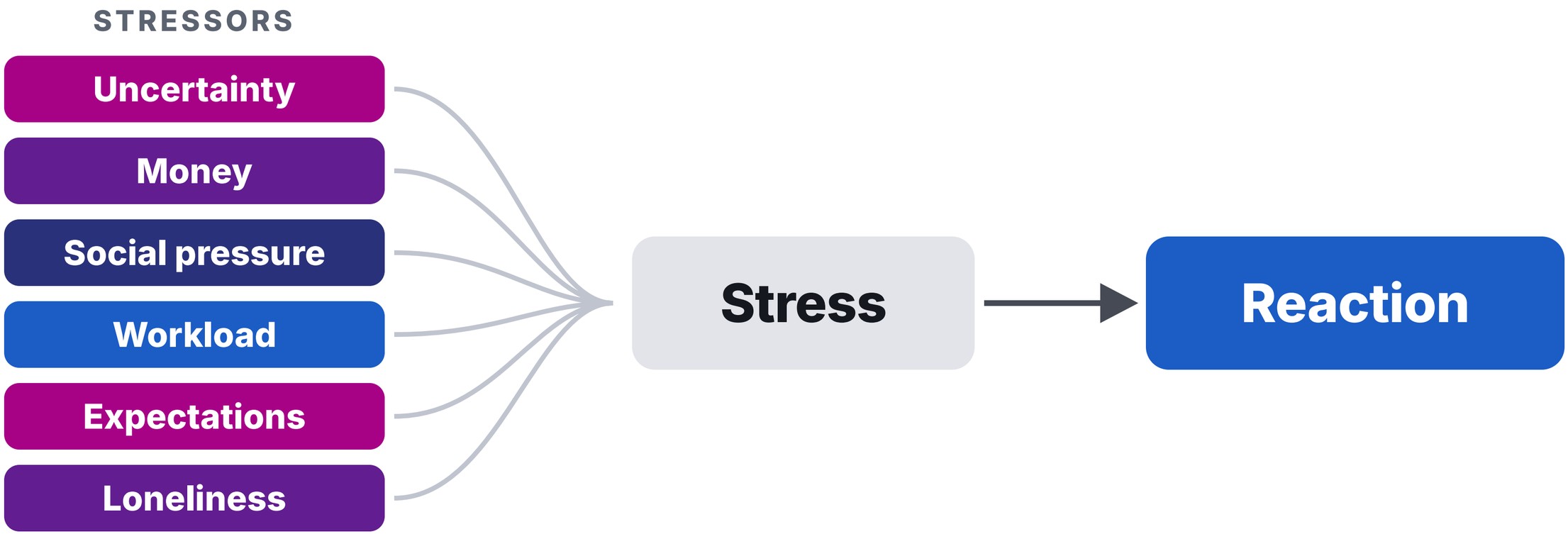
Step back

from the role

CASE · BRIDGE · YOUR STEP 2

Say it before it is a house of cards

Ask each co-founder one question about how they really are, and only listen



WHERE TO GET HELP

More than a bad week? Talk to someone

A bad week is normal. More? Talk to someone outside the team



Talk to someone	Your doctor, university counselling or a founder you trust
Germany, now	TelefonSeelsorge 0800 111 0 111 or 0800 111 0 222, free, day and night
Austria · Switzerland	142 · 143
Emergency	112
Elsewhere	findahelpline.com

DATA Official sites as of 20 October 2026, telefonseelsorge.de, telefonseelsorge.at, 143.ch, digital-strategy.ec.europa.eu (112), findahelpline.com. In Switzerland your phone provider may charge a fee. More in the course resource Getting help. Photo: MabelAmber on Pixabay.

See you next time!